



Gianugo Rabellino delivering the keynote: "Microsoft, Open Source, And Interoperability—What's Ahead!" at OSI Days 2011

where we have various challenges, and where my team happened to be hosting the interoperability challenge. I think it's always great to see people trying to do something new with passion.

Q In India, within the open source world, there has been a major transition from hostility towards Microsoft to accepting the firm as one more player with respect to open source. At the global level, do you observe the community harbouring any apprehensions towards Microsoft?

GR: Well, the answer is twofold. In fact, based on my interaction with the open source community all these years, I can say that the open source community is very approachable. So when you reach out to the community of developers in the open community, you realise they bring along with them their culture of exploration and seeking solutions to problems. When we work with them, we adapt to this culture. Frankly, I'm yet to see a community that does not want to work with us.

As far as particular problems are concerned, my experience so far has been that in general, people are willing to talk to us and, more than that, people are looking forward to having a technical discussion on how they can make things better, how they could work on building a solution, use our technology, etc.

So we have evolved many ways of helping and of being more open with the open source community.

Q Are you as open to working with small open source communities like CRM software vendors, as you are with the communities related to large projects like Ruby on Rails and PHP? How do the smaller projects engage Microsoft?

GR: That's exactly what my job is all about! I am the person to reach out to for all open source communities. I'll be more than happy to assist them. It's essentially why I get my salary. The more the projects engage with us, the better it is. And we always are open to finding a way forward to help them.

Q Mandar, correct me if I am wrong, but are you the contact point for the Indian open source community to engage with, at Microsoft?

MN: Absolutely. I am the single point of contact for anyone trying to reach out to Microsoft in India for open source related issues. Obviously, I have global support from Gianugo and the team, so it would be great if open source enthusiasts reached out to us. My email address is mandar.naik@microsoft.com, and they can reach me directly. I will try to help them out as quickly as possible.

Q Not many open source projects are being initiated in India, despite the fact that Indians are increasingly deploying open source. Do you find these communities reaching out from India?

MN: When we participated at Open Source India last year, we launched quite a few development tools. There were a lot of open source contributors from the Indian market too, who participated. And there were global companies also, apart from Indian companies, that participated.

However, let me point out that the open source community in India is more consumption oriented. I think it is up to the community itself and up to people like you, representing LFY, and to us to take this initiative forward. Because one little problem within India is, when people think about open source, they think about specific platforms. They need to realise that open source is about community development and it's not about the economics. When that realisation dawns, we'll see traction happening.

Q There've been some attempts to connect with the open source community of India through competitions. Can you share some details about this initiative?

MN: Last year, we launched a contest for open source developers through which we invited them to create applications and compete. That went really well. So we have had tremendous traction with developers wanting to do that.

Q Are you planning to repeat the competition in India this year?

MN: We definitely want to continue with the initiative. We want to make it an annual affair, if possible. This will help us establish a much more holistic culture to support the development process.

Q Last year, you had also launched an interesting engagement programme for developers to try out the Azure platform. How did that go? Did it meet your expectations?

MN: Well, yes and no. When I say yes, I mean that there was tremendous excitement. We saw a lot of developers enrolling for the facilities and tool kits. We could also reach out to a lot of open source developers and we got a lot of folks interested in working with us.